

much harder. But there was no easy day!" she says.

Rifle shooters also compete with a customised jacket and trousers that provide additional stiffness, and there too Meghana had to adjust. "I had some extra material, so I was always stretching and making alterations to the kit," she says.

Meghana first competed for India in 2017. Last year, she won her first World Cup medal: a bronze in the women's 10m air rifle in Ningbo, while three months pregnant.

But as her pregnancy progressed, things got harder. "We had to reduce the amount of training she was doing. It was difficult for her to stand on her feet for long sessions, so we had to reduce her workload," Manpat says.

Despite this, Meghana's performances in international events and selection trials earned her a spot at the Asian Championships. She was adamant she would compete.

"Initially, when Meghana told me last December that she wanted to compete at the Asian Championships in February, I didn't think too much about it because at that time she was only six months pregnant. But then I realised that she would be in her last month before delivery in February! So I spoke to our sports scientists and physios to check if there could be any problem that we needed to watch out for. But they all agreed that she was fit and ready to compete," says Deshpande.

Supportive teammates

Even as Meghana continued to train, her teammates and coaches were supportive. "My teammates do treat me differently. It's a little hard for me to pack up after I shoot, so they help me lift all my stuff. That's helped me out a lot," she says.

It was all up to her, though, at the Karni Singh Range at the Asian Championships.

"Typically, finals are difficult for Meghana. But this time, the qualification was equivalent to a final. Being able to stand for so long in the same position is extremely



difficult. After the first series, she was struggling. Meghana later told me that it was the most difficult day of shooting in her career," Manpat says.

Hard as it was, Meghana came through with a medal. It's a result her coaches are proud of. "It's broken a few barriers for women. I think a lot of people today would have watched her and rethought what they felt was possible for women athletes," says Deshpande.

It might even be a sign of bigger things to come, Manpat says. "The fact that Meghana could get the kind of result she got when few others would even have tried to compete shows the kind of character and resilience she has. It should give her so much confidence for the future,"

Perfect poise: Meghana Sajjanar's Asian Championships bronze became her most memorable medal yet.

he says.

Meghana feels that way as well. "I think I challenged myself more through this experience than through anything I've done. I'm mentally prepared to deal with any situation in the future," she says.

With a medal won in such difficult circumstances, most athletes would want to keep going. And while there is another selection trial next month, Meghana will, for now, pack up her gun and kit. But not for long. "After my delivery, I'm going to be taking a break for the next three months. But then I'll be back shooting!" she says.